

The Last Star Counter

A heartwarming children's story about courage and dreams

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By J.K. Blaze

Chapter 1: The Most Important Job in the World

Luna pressed her nose against the cool bedroom window and counted: "One, two, three, four..."

The stars twinkled like diamonds scattered across black velvet. Each one waited patiently for her to find it, name it, and keep it safe.

"Five, six, seven..." she whispered, her breath fogging the glass.

"Luna, time for bed!" called her mother from downstairs.

"Just a few more minutes, please!" Luna called back. She couldn't stop now. Not when the stars needed her.

Her grandmother had taught her the secret when Luna was only five years old. They'd sat together on this same windowsill, wrapped in Grandma's quilted blanket that smelled like lavender and old books.

"Every star needs to be counted each night," Grandma had whispered, her wrinkled finger pointing at the sky. "If even one is forgotten, it grows lonely and fades away forever."

"But there are so many!" Luna had gasped.

Grandma's eyes had sparkled like the stars themselves. "That's why we take turns, little one. Your great-grandmother counted them before me. I've counted them for sixty years. And someday, when I'm too old, you'll take over."

That someday had come last winter, when Grandma got too sick to climb the stairs. Before she went to the hospital for the last time, she'd pressed a worn leather journal into Luna's hands.

"The Star Counter's Book," Grandma had said. "Every star has a page, a name, and a story. Don't let them be forgotten."

Now, three months later, Luna was the last Star Counter in the world. Every single night, she sat at her window and counted. Sometimes it took an hour. Sometimes it took three.

"Twenty-three, twenty-four, twenty-five..."

Tonight felt different, though. The stars seemed brighter, more restless somehow. They pulsed and shimmered like they were trying to tell her something.

"Luna Marie!" her mother called again, firmer this time. "Bed. Now."

Luna sighed and opened Grandma's journal. The pages were yellow with age and filled with careful handwriting in faded blue ink. Each page had a star's name at the top: "Cornelius the Brave," "Whisper-Wind Martha," "Dancing Diego."

She found tonight's count on the last page she'd written: 847 stars total. All present and accounted for.

But as she prepared to close the journal, something made her look up one more time.

There, in the darkest corner of sky, a new star flickered to life.

848.

Luna's heart raced. A new star meant a new story, a new name, a new life depending on her. She grabbed her pencil and turned to a fresh page.

"Hello there," she whispered to the tiny light. "I see you. You're safe now."

The star seemed to pulse brighter, as if it had heard her.

Luna smiled and began to write. She would name this one "Hope" because that's exactly what it looked like—a small, bright hope in the darkness.

She had no idea that this new star would change everything.

Chapter 2: The Night Everything Went Wrong

Three weeks later, Luna had fallen into a perfect rhythm. Every night at eight o'clock, she'd climb the stairs to her room, open Grandma's journal, and begin her count.

Hope had settled nicely into its spot in the northwestern sky. Luna had written its story on page 419: "Hope arrived on a Tuesday when the moon was hiding. It likes to wink at the other stars and make them laugh. Hope is the youngest star in the sky, but also the bravest."

848 stars, every single night. Never one more, never one less.

Until tonight.

Luna rubbed her eyes and counted again. She'd been feeling strange all day—heavy and tired,

like she was walking through honey. Maybe she'd gotten the flu that was going around school.

"One, two, three..." she began again, squinting at the familiar patterns. Her eyelids felt like they had tiny weights attached to them.

She reached for Grandma's journal to help focus her mind, but her fingers felt clumsy and thick. The book tumbled from her hands and hit the floor with a thud.

"Forty-one, forty-two, forty..." Luna blinked hard. Where was she in the count? Had she already counted the Big Dipper? What about the constellation that looked like a dancing rabbit?

Her head nodded forward, and she jerked awake. This was bad. Very, very bad.

"I can't fall asleep," she whispered to the stars. "You need me."

Hope pulsed in the distance, and Luna could have sworn it looked worried.

She pinched her own arm. She splashed cold water from her bedside glass on her face. She even tried doing jumping jacks in her pajamas, but her legs felt wobbly and weak.

"810... 811... 812..." The numbers felt thick and strange in her mouth.

Luna's mother peeked into the room. "Honey, you look awful. Do you feel okay?"

"I'm fine," Luna lied, though she definitely wasn't. Her throat felt scratchy, and her forehead was hot. "Just counting."

"Maybe skip it tonight? The stars will be fine for one evening."

Luna's stomach dropped to her toes. "No! I can't skip. They need-"

But even as she protested, her eyelids were closing. She fought against the drowsiness with everything she had, but it was like trying to hold back the ocean with her bare hands.

"830... 831..."

The numbers grew quieter and quieter until they were just whispers. Luna's chin dropped to her chest, and the Star Counter's journal slid forgotten from her lap.

Outside her window, 17 stars flickered uncertainly in the darkness, waiting to be counted.

But for the first time in four years, no one was watching.

And slowly, one by one, they began to fade.

Chapter 3: The Morning After

Luna woke to screaming.

Not human screaming-something worse. A sound like wind crying, like metal bending, like the world itself was in pain.

She shot up in bed, her heart hammering. Sunlight streamed through her window, which meant she'd slept through the entire night. The Star Counter's journal lay open on the floor, its pages scattered.

"No, no, no," she whispered, scrambling to gather the papers. "I fell asleep. I actually fell asleep."

The screaming sound came again, and this time Luna realized what it was. It was the sky itself, mourning.

She pressed her face to the window and gasped.

The sky was wrong. Horribly, impossibly wrong.

During the day, the sky was supposed to be blue and cheerful. But now it looked pale and sick, like milk left out too long. Gray cracks spread across it like spider webs, and in some places, Luna could see straight through to the darkness beyond.

"Mom!" she called, but her voice came out as a croak. Her throat felt like sandpaper.

Her mother rushed in with a thermometer and a worried expression. "Oh sweetheart, you have a fever. No school today."

"Mom, look outside," Luna said urgently. "The sky-"

"I know, honey. There's some kind of unusual weather pattern. They're talking about it on the news. But don't worry about that now. You need rest."

Luna stared at her mother. Couldn't she see? Couldn't she understand?

17 stars had faded last night. And when stars died, they left holes in the sky.

Luna waited until her mother left, then grabbed Grandma's journal with shaking hands. She flipped through the pages, checking each star's story, each carefully drawn map showing where to find them in the sky.

There-Twinkle-Toe Timothy, who liked to dance with the moon. Gone.

Sweet Susanna, who sang lullabies to sleeping children. Gone.

Brave Benjamin, who watched over lost travelers. Gone.

Seventeen stars total. Seventeen holes in the sky. Seventeen stories that would never be told again.

And it was all her fault.

Luna's fever made everything feel fuzzy and strange, like she was watching the world through frosted glass. But one thing was crystal clear: she had to fix this. Somehow, she had to bring the stars back.

She opened to a blank page in the journal and began to write:

Day 1 after the Great Forgetting: 17 stars lost to my carelessness. The sky is cracking. I don't know if stars can be brought back once they're gone, but I have to try. Gran

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